

Music at Carleton
presents

Susie Park
in concert with
Timothy Lovelace

Sunday, February 8, 2026
3:00PM | Kracum Performance Hall

PROGRAM

Sonata No. 1 in A minor, Op. 105 for violin and piano

ROBERT SCHUMANN

Mit leidenschaftlichem Ausdruck

Allegretto

Lebhaft

Sonata in D for violin and piano

MAURICE RAVEL

Allegretto

Blues; Moderato

Perpetuum mobile; Allegro

Intermission

Three Romances Opus 22 for violin and piano

CLARA SCHUMANN

Andante molto

Allegretto *Mit zartem Vortrage*

Leidenschaftlich schnell

Sonata in G major Opus 78 for violin and piano

JOHANNES BRAHMS

Vivace ma non troppo

Adagio

Allegro molto moderato

As a courtesy, please turn off all cell phones, do not use flash photography, and refrain from leaving during the performance. Your cooperation is greatly appreciated.

BIOGRAPHIES

Hailed as “prodigiously talented” (Washington Post) and praised for her “freedom, mastery and fantasy” (La Libre, Belgium), Sydney native **Susie Park** first picked up a violin at age three, made her solo debut at five, and, by fifteen, had performed with every major orchestra in her country. Park has grown into a musician distinguished by unusual passion and versatility, and today performs internationally as an orchestral, chamber, and solo artist.

Park’s international career was launched at age 16, when she took first place in the Yehudi Menuhin International Competition in France. This led to performances and re-engagements throughout the US, Europe, and her native Australia, where highlights include performances for crowds of over 135,000. Park went on to receive additional top prizes at the International Violin Competition of Indianapolis and the Wieniawski Competition in Poland.

Park has since concertized around the world, soloing and touring with European orchestras including the Vienna Symphony, Orchestre National de Lille, and the Royal Philharmonic; American orchestras including the Pittsburgh, San Francisco and Indianapolis Symphonies; Korea’s KBS Orchestra; Orchestra Wellington in New Zealand; and all major symphony orchestras in Australia. Working with conductors including Simon Rattle, Hans Vonk, Alan Gilbert, Fabio Luisi and Yehudi Menuhin, Park has performed in venues ranging from New York’s Carnegie and Alice Tully Halls, Boston’s Symphony Hall, Chicago’s Millennium Park, Philadelphia’s Kimmel Center, Washington’s Smithsonian Institute, Vienna’s Musikverein, Cologne’s Philharmonie, Düsseldorf’s Tonhalle, and the Sydney Opera House.

“Especially haunting...moving, persuasive performance” -New York Times.

Park, formerly the violinist of the Eroica Trio from 2006 to 2012, recorded the ensemble’s eighth CD; an all-American Grammy-nominated album, and toured internationally with the trio in countries including Germany, Denmark, New Zealand and Austria. She was also a member of the Chamber Music Society of Lincoln Center Two, collaborating with artists such as Wu Han, Gary Hoffman and Ida Kavafian. For three consecutive summers she attended the Marlboro Music Festival, and has appeared on numerous Musicians from Marlboro tours. Park has performed chamber music with members of the Guarneri, Juilliard, Emerson, and Cleveland Quartets, as well as Kim Kashkashian, Pamela Frank, Jason Vieaux, Anthony Marwood, Cho-Liang Lin, and Jaime Laredo. Her festival engagements include Music from Angel Fire, Music in the Vineyards, Napa, the Seattle, Caramoor, Skaneateles, Aspen, Ravinia, Portland Maine, Portland Oregon, Bowdoin and Salt Bay festivals in the US; Open Chamber Music at Prussia Cove in England; Bermuda Festival; the Mozarteum Sommerakademie in Austria; and Keshet Eilon in Israel. She regularly performs with Accordo, a chamber music ensemble comprising principal string players from the Minnesota Orchestra and the Saint Paul Chamber Orchestra.

BIBLIOGRAPHIES CONT.

“Park plays with a sweet, acutely focused tone, and her mix of musical elegance and bristling virtuosity fits her colleagues’ style like a well-tailored glove.” -Miami Herald.

Park was appointed first associate concertmaster of the Minnesota Orchestra in 2015, and has served as guest concertmaster of the St. Paul Chamber Orchestra as well as the Pittsburgh, Seattle and Indianapolis Symphonies. She is also a founding member of ECCO, the East Coast Chamber Orchestra, a conductorless chamber orchestra based upon democratic principles, whose focus is to be purely on music-making and comprises some of the most talented young chamber musicians, soloists and principal string players in major American orchestras. Translating this diversity of experience and virtuosity into a unified ensemble approach, ECCO combines the strength and power of an orchestral ensemble with the personal, intimate nature of chamber music. In 2012, ECCO released a recording of fresh takes on some of the most popular and compelling music from three different centuries. The virtuosity and spirit of the music-making soar on this self-titled debut album of beloved works by Tchaikovsky, Shostakovich and Geminiani, released on the eOne label.

“A world-class artist, the US-based Australian’s sweet-toned, finely balanced violin playing was the highlight...” -The Australian

Other recent highlights include being a jury member for the Michael Hill International Violin Competition in New Zealand; being on faculty of the Bowdoin International Music Festival; being on the faculty of the Cuban American Youth Orchestra, touring her home country as guest first violinist of the Australian String Quartet which prompted the The Australian to publish a review headlined “Australian String Quartet proof Susie Park’s one we let get away;” touring India and the UK with the Australian World Orchestra under the baton of Zubin Mehta, and joining the Enso String Quartet as first violinist for their final season.

“switching from spiky to lush and back with fearless verve, flair and energy...compelling and genuinely moving” -Sydney Morning Herald

Park’s diverse musical interests have also led to collaborations with artists such as trumpeter Chris Botti, with whom she performed 41 consecutive shows at the Blue Note jazz club in New York.

Park holds degrees from the Curtis Institute and the New England Conservatory; her principal teachers include Jaime Laredo, Ida Kavafian, Donald Weilerstein, Miriam Fried, Shi-Xiang (Peter) Zhang, and Christopher Kimber.

BIOGRAPHIES CONT.

She plays a J.B. Guadagnini violin made in 1740, once featured in a documentary of which Park herself was a subject.

Park enjoys knitting, garment design and other creative arts.

Her 2025 live performance of Gabriela Ortiz' violin concerto, "Altar de Cuerda" with the Minnesota Orchestra is available to view at this link on YouTube:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Bn_NWPUIQpA

Pianist and conductor **Timothy Lovelace** heads the Collaborative Piano program at the University of Minnesota and is an active recitalist, having been featured at Rio de Janeiro's Sala Cecilia Meireles, Carnegie's Weill Recital Hall, Washington's Kennedy Center, New York's Merkin Concert Hall, Chicago's Dame Myra Hess Memorial Concerts, and on series sponsored by the symphony orchestras of Chicago, Cincinnati, Detroit, Minnesota, and the Saint Paul Chamber Orchestra. As a soloist, Lovelace has performed with the Minnesota Orchestra conducted by Osmo Vänskä.

The roster of artists with whom Lovelace has appeared includes Miriam Fried, Nobuko Imai, Robert Mann, Charles Neidich, Paquito D'Rivera, and Dawn Upshaw. For thirteen years, he was a staff pianist at the Ravinia Festival's Steans Institute, where he played in the classes of Barbara Bonney, Christoph Eschenbach, Thomas Hampson, Christa Ludwig and Yo-Yo Ma, among others.

Lovelace has conducted the Civic Orchestra of Minneapolis, the Saint Paul Chamber Orchestra, the Virginia Beach Symphony (now Symphonicity), and the symphony orchestras of the University of Cincinnati College-Conservatory and the University of Minnesota. A proponent of new music, he has performed the works of many living composers and has presented premieres of works by John Harbison, Osvaldo Golijov, and Libby Larsen. He himself is a published composer.

Lovelace has recorded for the Albany, Arabesque, Blue Griffin, Boston Records, MSR, and Naxos labels. His principal teachers were Harold Evans, Clifford Herzer, Gilbert Kalish, Donna Loewy, Gerhard Samuel, and Frank Weinstock.

PROGRAM NOTES

ROBERT SCHUMANN (1810-1856)

Sonata No. 1 in A minor, Op. 105 for violin and piano

In August 1850 Schumann arrived in Düsseldorf amid great fanfare to take up the position of town music director. By the next season, however, problems had developed with management and musicians alike, augmented by his progressing mental illness. Nevertheless, he strove to improve the town's musical life by organizing a small select group of singers and a short-lived ensemble of instrumentalists. Thus in the fall of 1851 he had vocal and instrumental chamber music on his mind.

The time was now ripe to act on an 1850 request by Ferdinand David, concertmaster of the Gewandhaus Orchestra in Leipzig for a violin and piano piece. Schumann composed his first violin sonata—A minor, op. 105—between September 12 and 16, 1851, and after a pause to write the G minor Piano Trio, continued with a second—D minor, op. 121—between October 26 and November 2.

Clara Schumann, her husband's greatest champion and interpreter, immediately learned the piano part and played the first private performance of the A minor Violin Sonata on October 16 with Wilhelm Joseph von Wasielewski, Robert's talented young concertmaster. She wrote in her diary: "We were particularly moved by the very elegiac first movement and the lovely second movement." The third movement, she said, caused them some difficulties, and though they played it through three more times Wasielewski reported that they were unable to convey its "brusque tone" to the composer's satisfaction.

The first public performance took place on March 29 at the Leipzig Gewandhaus with David, who had first suggested such a work, and he received the dedication when Schumann published it in 1852. Clara continued to play the piece after her husband's death, most often with the rising young star Joseph Joachim.

Schumann's first movement, designated "With passionate expression," sets a mood of quiet unrest with the main theme beginning in the violin's low, throaty range. Throughout, the piano does not merely "arpeggiate," but exhibits the distinctive multiple voices and textures that are quintessentially Schumann. A special feature of this movement is the masterful blurring of the border between development and recapitulation that became such a Romantic art.

PROGRAM NOTES CONT.

The Allegretto shows the intimate charm of many of Schumann's piano miniatures. Twice he interrupts with contrasting episodes—the first in the contemplative manner of Eusebius, the introverted fictional character of his prose and musical writings, and the second à la Florestan, his happy, extroverted persona.

The finale cavorts like a scherzo, but with a demonic cast, as opposed to the elfin scherzos characteristic of Schumann's contemporary Mendelssohn. A wonderful major-mode middle episode imparts a lyrical warmth to offset the more “brusque” drive of the main theme. Toward the end Schumann shows his concern for unity across movements by reintroducing the low restless main theme of the first movement before the final fiendish push to the close.

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MAURICE RAVEL (1875-1937)

Violin and Piano Sonata No. 2 for violin and piano

Ravel began work in 1923 on a sonata for violin and piano, and found himself intrigued, not by the union, but by the independence of the instrumental parts. Ravel explained his reason for writing for the instruments as he did by describing the piano and violin of his Sonata as “essentially incompatible instruments, which not only do not sink their differences, but accentuate incompatibility to an even greater degree.” (Which may explain why he did not finish it until 1927.) Always the intellectual and the consummate craftsman, Ravel proved his argument with a work in which the two instruments are separate but equal, reacting to each other dispassionately, yet each maintaining its distinct identity.

The first movement begins with the piano presenting a flowing melody having a distinctive quick step that interrupts the even motion. The violin takes up the idea while the piano falls into a repeated broken octave pattern in the treble which is joined by an impudent little figure in the bass destined to make many appearances throughout the movement, and a reappearance at the beginning of the third movement. The music unfolds with remarkable textural economy; for example, in one section the piano accompanies an expressive violin melody with only an extended series of archaic two-note figures (simultaneously sounded notes a fifth apart).

The second movement, titled Blues, is a slightly self-conscious nod to the American idiom Ravel greatly admired. Syncopations, honky-tonk rhythmic patterns, flatted thirds and sevenths, violin slides, and an allusion to the dialog between the Teapot and the Cup in his opera *L'Enfant et les sortilèges* are some of the elements that make up the Blues.

PROGRAM NOTES CONT.

Starting with a remembrance of the first movement's cheeky figure, the finale finds the violin taking off, locomotive style, on a perpetual motion of dizzying virtuosic activity, while the piano works its jaunty rhythmic way through a variety of material, including some echoes from the earlier movements. The design is highly original, the effect riveting and hypnotic.

— Orrin Howard

CLARA WIECK SHUMANN (1819-1896)

Three Romances, Op. 22 for Violin and Piano (1853)

Clara Schumann is known today mainly as the wife of composer Robert Schumann and the intimate friend of Johannes Brahms. In her 61-year concert career, however, she was considered one of the most distinguished pianists of her day, and was highly influential in programming new works by contemporary Romantic composers. She was also a prolific composer in her early years, but at a time when women composers were frowned on by the music world.

At the age of eight, young Clara performed at a musical evening in a Leipzig home, and there she met another gifted young pianist, Robert Schumann, nine years older. Schumann admired Clara's playing so much that he asked permission from his mother to discontinue his studies of the law and take music lessons from Clara's father, Friedrich Wieck, a prominent music teacher. In the custom of the day, he took a room in his teacher's household, and by the time she was 17 they were in love.

On Clara's 18th birthday, Schumann asked her father for Clara's hand in marriage, but he refused and took his daughter on a long concert tour to break up the relationship. When the couple persisted, Wieck threatened to cut Clara off financially, and the lovers took him to court to win Clara's independence. They married after her 21st birthday.

Clara continued to perform publicly even as she raised seven children, extending her own reputation beyond Germany. In these concert tours, she was instrumental in changing the programs of concert pianists, playing from memory and programming works of musical depth as well as bravura pieces designed to show off keyboard technique. She also appeared in chamber music recitals, and vigorously promoted the music of younger composers, particularly Robert and their young friend Brahms.

PROGRAM NOTES CONT.

Clara had less success, however, in winning the skeptical public to her music. She had begun composing as a youngster, writing her first piano concerto at 14 and performing it at 16 in Leipzig with Mendelssohn conducting. As she grew older, however, she lost confidence in herself as a composer, writing “I once believed that I possessed creative talent, but I have given up this idea; a woman must not desire to compose – there has never yet been one able to do it.” As things turned out, she composed nothing after the age of 34 other than some cadenzas for Beethoven and Mozart piano concertos.

Before that turning point, she had a final burst of creative activity in 1853, producing, between concerts, some variations on a theme by Robert, three romances for the piano, *six lieder*, and these three romances for the violin and piano. She published these works in the next two years, and then with Robert’s death in 1856, gave up composing to devote herself to the promotion of his music and that of their friend Brahms.

Clara dedicated the three romances for violin and piano to another friend, the great violinist Joseph Joachim, and she performed them with him often on her concert tours. After her death in 1896, the romances were largely forgotten along with the rest of her music. In recent years, however, the growing interest in women composers has revived performances of her music, and the three romances are again heard in the concert hall and on recordings. “Romance” was a title favored by both Robert and Clara for an instrumental piece that is lyrical in character and tender or even sentimental in mood. In this case, Clara demonstrated a gift for melody and produced true chamber music with the two instruments on an equal footing rather than with the piano in an accompanying role. We can only wonder what she might have achieved if she had lived a century later.

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PROGRAM NOTES CONT.

JOHANNES BRAHMS (1833-1897)

Sonata for Violin and Piano No. 1, in G Major, Op. 78

In his first twenty years, Johannes Brahms made an astonishing leap, from a miserable childhood in the downtrodden harbor area of Hamburg to an eminent position as a distinguished young composer. He began his career as a musician at the age of twelve by giving piano lessons for pennies, and at thirteen, he was playing in harbor-side sailors' bars. By the age of sixteen, however, he had progressed to playing Beethoven's *Waldstein Sonata* and one of his own compositions in a public concert. In April 1853, just before his 20th birthday, he set out from Hamburg on a modest concert tour, traveling mostly on foot. In Hanover, he called on the violinist Joseph Joachim, who at twenty-two had just become the head of the royal court orchestra there. Brahms so impressed Joachim that he gave him a letter of introduction to Liszt in Weimar and sent him to see Schumann in Düsseldorf. When Schumann, who was then Germany's leading composer, and his wife, Clara, one of Europe's greatest pianists heard Brahms play, they took him into their home.

Although this sonata purports to be Brahms's *Violin Sonata No. 1*, according to the reflections of a student of Brahms, Brahms had presumably discarded five violin sonatas that he had composed before he wrote this one, the first that he thought good enough to preserve and present to the world. He wrote this work during the summers of 1878 and 1879, when he had already become a mature artist. It was his only piece of chamber music from the productive period in which he composed his *Symphony No. 2*, the *Academic Festival* and *Tragic Overtures*, the *Violin Concerto* and *Piano Concerto No. 2*.

This sonata, like his *Violin Concerto*, Op. 77, owes a great deal to Joachim and to Clara Schumann, who by then was a widow. Clara was a distinguished pianist and composer in her own right. When Brahms sent Clara a manuscript copy of this new work, she wrote back, "I must send you a line to tell you how excited I am about your Sonata. It came today. Of course I played it through at once, and at the end could not help bursting into tears of joy." Ten years later, when Clara was seventy years old and in failing health, she still loved the sonata and treasured the friendship of both Joachim and Brahms. From her house in Frankfurt she wrote a touching letter to Brahms in which she said, "Joachim was here on Robert's eightieth birthday and we had a lot of music. We played the [Op. 78] Sonata again and I reveled in it. I wish that the last movement could accompany me in my journey from here to the next world."

PROGRAM NOTES CONT.

This sonata is one of the most lyrical compositions among all of Brahms's instrumental works. The violin always has the leading voice, and the piano writing is always so clear and transparent that an imbalance never exists between the two instruments. There are only three movements, not the usual four frequently considered traditional for a sonata; Brahms wrote to his publisher, clearly in jest, that since he came up one movement short, he would therefore accept 25% less than his usual fee for this work.

As in many of Brahms' compositions, the movements are intimately interrelated. A three-note motto figure is common to all three movements. A mood of gentle nostalgia permeates the first movement, *Vivace ma non troppo*, and sets the tone and character for the entire sonata. Brahms here works much like Beethoven had before him: he introduces a germ out of which the themes for the whole movement eventually evolve and grow. The second movement is a solemn and dramatic *Adagio*. The third, a rondo, *Allegro molto moderato*, contains an episode in which Brahms brings back the lovely slow movement theme. The principal melodic material of this movement, however, comes from a related pair of his songs, "*Regenlied*" ("*Rain Song*") and "*Nachklang*" ("*Reminiscence*"), Op. 59, Nos. 3 and 4.